

From Ultra to Uber Portability

Five Examples To Prove Our Point

We are truly in the age of ultra-portability, living in the midst of laptops, netbooks, tablets, smart phones and e-book readers, with retractable keyboards, multi-touch capacitive screens, projected keypads, foldable displays and many more seemingly-futuristic but actually realistic features

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"Magical and revolutionary" is what Apple calls its iPad. Perhaps it is, but not alone. In a way, these adjectives describe the collective impact of this whole generation of ultra-portable computing devices—laptops, netbooks, tablets, e-book readers and the like. Lightweight, compact, power-efficient, application-intensive, these devices pack in all that you would want within a small form factor. However, the truth is that we have seen only the tip of the iceberg. The best is yet to come. From retractable keypads to pico-projector displays, there is a lot more on the anvil.

A recap of *CeBIT 2010*, one of the most well-known annual consumer electronics shows in the world, is sufficient to prove this point. From 3D-ready displays and touch panels to next-generation audio capabilities, the laptops had them all. Not to forget ASUS' green laptop with bamboo panels and Lenovo's hybrid laptop—a notebook from which you can detach the screen to use as an independent multi-touch tablet. Then, just as Apple launched its much-acclaimed iPad in the market, Nokia announced plans to enter the tablet market, as also other computer makers such as Samsung and HP.

With advanced features and appropriate toolsets, the popularity of ultra-portable personal computers (PCs)

amongst enterprises is understandable. However, the ultra-portable fever has not spared even the young generation. A recent Gartner study emphasises that by 2015, more than 50 per cent of the computers bought for children below 15 years will have touch screens. Keep your ears open, and you are likely to hear teens discussing the gaming experience on such-and-such a notebook computer or tablet. Schools and colleges are ordering netbooks in bulk for their students, while housewives and senior citizens are finding these convenient for their simple usage.

"The notebook market in India is gradually coming of age with affordable mobile computing devices, the cellular explosion in India and wireless local area network (LAN). We believe that the future of mobile computing lies in convergence and the ever-changing needs of an increasing customer base. Personal computers are constantly metamorphosing into newer *avatars* with better convenience to suit the consumer. Ultra-mobile PCs, popularised by tablet PCs and mobile Internet devices (MIDs), are revolutionising the mobile computing domain," says Amar Babu, managing director, Lenovo India.

In short, portable PCs of all genres are seeing a boom time, and obviously there is a lot of innovation happening in the space as well. Here is a quick

look at five such interesting innovations and research ventures.

1 OLPC's \$75 dream

A \$75 tablet? Yes, the One Laptop Per Child (OLPC) project has managed to break our mundane visions of 'reality' once again. We are talking about the futuristic XO-3 designed by Yves Behar for the OLPC project. While one segment of tech watchers wants this device to be mass produced and sold in the open market so they too could buy one, there is an equally vehement opposition commenting that the OLPC is wasting its money on a fantastic but futuristic design that is really not a necessity for third-world children to come up in life. "What happened to the simple laptops they designed? Are they being used? Can we have a report on their effect," the critics ask on the various forums.

Anyway, popular opinion apart, the device by itself is an innovative one. As usual, even if Nicholas Ne-



OLPC project laptop